Lecture 16

Revisions & Discussions- Mid-term Test

Prof Jayati Bhattacharya

Email: iimkjayati@gmail.com

Syllabus for the Mid-term Examination

- Lecture 1: Why Study History
- Lecture 2: Historical Methods, Sources and Practices
- Lecture 3: Global and Regional Histories
- Lecture 4: Indian Schools of Historical Thought
- Lecture 6: India through the Eyes of Foreign Travellers
- Lecture 7: Commercial and Cultural Exchanges… Baghdad to Canton
- Lecture 8: India and the Silk Route Connections- I
- Lecture 9: India and the Silk Route Connections- II
- Lecture 10: Religions in India
- Lecture 11: History of the Indian Ocean as a Connected Space

Structure of the Question Paper

- Mid-term test will be a closed-book examination
- The Full Marks for the examination is 50
- Time allotted- 2 hours
- There will be three sections in the question paper. You must attempt questions from all sections
  - Section A: MCQs [10x 0.5= 5marks]
  - Section B: Short questions (Any 3 out of 5) [3x 10=30 marks]
  - Section C: Essay type question (Any 1 out of 2/ 3) [1x15= 15 marks]

General guidelines and suggestions

- Read the question carefully.
- The question will guide you to write the desired answer.

- Take into consideration the marks allotted for the question
- Make a mental note/ rough sketch of the points to be included

- Write with a proper introduction and conclusion
- Write in short and clear paragraphs, not bullet points
- Any example of people, events, date, scholars, methods, publications as and where applicable will enhance your writing

- Remain conscious of your time allotment for each answer (this will depend on individual capability and personal time management)

- There is no specific and pre-determined length or word-count for the answers.
- Marks will depend on your content, language and presentation style

Sample question and guidelines for answer

Why is it important to distinguish between religious doctrines and lived religious practices in understanding religion in India?

Model Answer

The distinction between **religious doctrine and lived religion** is important because formal teachings do not necessarily determine how religion is actually experienced and practised by people. Religious traditions provide beliefs, texts, rituals and principles, but these are interpreted and adapted within particular social and cultural contexts.

This may be demonstrated clearly through the history of Islam in India. Islam contains universal principles concerning belief in one God, the Qur'an, prayer, fasting, charity and pilgrimage. Yet Muslims in India lived within a society that already possessed established religious traditions, social institutions and cultural practices. Consequently, Islamic practice in India developed distinctive regional and cultural characteristics. One can observe that Indian Muslims could share the universal foundations of Islam while simultaneously being shaped by their geographical, linguistic, social and cultural circumstances.

The example of Kashmir is especially useful. The spread of Islam there involved not simply the transmission of Islamic doctrine but also the adaptation of religious teaching to existing cultural practices. The Rishi tradition associated with Nuruddin incorporated elements familiar from Kashmiri religious life, including vegetarianism and a concern for animals. This demonstrates how religious traditions could acquire local forms without necessarily losing their broader religious identity.

The same distinction is relevant to Hinduism. With reference to the Indian society, the interaction between the Brahmanical textual tradition may differ from local or popular rituals and practices. Rather than simply replacing existing practices, Brahmanical ideas could be incorporated into local traditions, while elements of popular religion could also become part of wider Hindu practice. This produced a religious landscape characterised by considerable variation and diversities, which has been an essence of Indian socio-cultural identity.

Christianity in India provides another example. Christian communities did not simply abandon their earlier social and cultural identities after conversion. The reading observes that different Christian communities retained aspects of their pre-conversion beliefs, social attitudes and ritual practices.

Thus, studying religion requires attention not only to **what religious texts prescribe**, but also to **how people interpret, negotiate and practise those teachings in everyday life**. Lived religion reveals the ways in which social circumstances, caste, region, culture and historical experience shape religious expression.

Sample question- Essay type along with guidelines

Evaluate the claim that the shift from colonial and nationalist history to Marxist "new history" represented a major advance in historical understanding

- Introduce the historiographical methods of Indian history in short and make a connection with the question asked
- Colonial and nationalist historiography had largely focused on civilizational judgments, political narratives, and identity-based arguments. Marxist history redirected attention toward structures of economy, society, class, and material life, thereby opening new ways of understanding the past.

- One major advance was the shift away from elite-centered narrative. Earlier histories often revolved around rulers, dynasties, political decline, or national greatness. Marxist approaches examined peasants, labor, land systems, production relations, and social hierarchy
- A second advance lay in explanation. Rather than treating events as isolated episodes or moral lessons, Marxist historians sought underlying causes in material structures and social relations.
- The new approach also corrected weaknesses in nationalist writing. Where nationalist historians sometimes used the past to foster pride or unity, Marxist historians were more likely to expose inequality, conflict, and contradiction within Indian society itself.

- Critique- Marxist history could itself become rigid when class became the master explanation for too wide a range of phenomena. Cultural, religious, regional, and intellectual dimensions of the past could be undervalued if they were treated merely as reflections of economic structure.
- Moreover, earlier phases should not be dismissed wholesale. Marxist history built on these foundations even while criticizing them. Historical understanding advances not by total replacement, but by layered revision.
- A strong conclusion would be that Marxist "new history" did represent a major advance because it broadened evidence, sharpened explanation, and shifted focus to deeper social and economic processes. However, it should be seen as one major stage in an evolving historiography rather than the final or complete form of historical understanding.